CHAPTER 8 · DEEP DIVE · A HOUSE DIVIDED

# Chickamauga & Chattanooga

A crushing Union defeat, a desperate siege, and the breakout that threw open the gateway to the Deep South. 1863.

**Name:** _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

*A crushing Union defeat, a desperate siege, and the breakout that threw open the gateway to the Deep South. 1863.*

How can an army lose a battle and still end up winning the campaign?

## The Door to Georgia

THE GATEWAY

After Gettysburg and Vicksburg, the war's center shifted to Chattanooga, Tennessee — a vital railroad hub and the gateway to Georgia and the heart of the Confederacy. Union General William Rosecrans cleverly maneuvered the Confederates out of the city without a fight.

But the Confederate army under Braxton Bragg was not finished. It turned and struck back just across the Georgia line, along a creek the Cherokee called Chickamauga — "River of Death."

*"Battle of Chickamauga, September 19–20, 1863" — chromolithograph, Kurz & Allison, public domain (Library of Congress).*

## The Battle of Chickamauga

SEPTEMBER 19–20, 1863

*A gap opened in the Union line, and the Confederates poured through, routing half of Rosecrans's army. It was one of the bloodiest battles of the war — and a Confederate victory.*

*"Battle of Chickamauga, September 19–20, 1863" — chromolithograph, Kurz & Allison, public domain (Library of Congress).*

## A Stand That Saved an Army

THE ROCK OF CHICKAMAUGA

As the Union right collapsed, General George Thomas held the left flank against assault after assault, buying time for the rest of the army to escape. His stand earned him the name "the Rock of Chickamauga."

But the victory was Bragg's. The battered Union army retreated into Chattanooga — and Bragg seized the heights above the city, Lookout Mountain and Missionary Ridge, trapping the Union army and cutting off its food.

*"Battle of Lookout Mountain, November 24, 1863" — chromolithograph, Kurz & Allison, public domain (Library of Congress).*

## The “Cracker Line”

THE SIEGE, AND THE RESCUE

The Union army in Chattanooga began to starve. Then Ulysses S. Grant arrived to take command. Within days he opened a new supply route — soldiers called it the “Cracker Line” — and food and reinforcements poured in.

In late November 1863, the revived Union army struck back. At the Battle of Lookout Mountain — the “Battle Above the Clouds,” fought in the fog — and then up the slopes of Missionary Ridge, Union troops stormed the heights and swept the Confederates off them.

*Turning points, 1863–65 — map, © ShadowDog Digital Studios (SDS Digital Collection).*

## The Battle Above the Clouds

NOVEMBER 1863

*Union soldiers fought their way up the fog-shrouded slopes of Lookout Mountain, then charged Missionary Ridge in a spontaneous, unstoppable rush that stunned both armies.*

*“Battle of Lookout Mountain, November 24, 1863” — chromolithograph, Kurz & Allison, public domain (Library of Congress).*

A UNION OFFICER AT MISSIONARY RIDGE

The men … seemed to be impelled by some irresistible force … up they went, over the works, and the day was won.

## The Gateway Swings Open

WHY IT MATTERS

The cost of Chickamauga had been terrible, but the effect of the whole campaign was decisive. With Chattanooga secured, the door to Georgia stood open.

From this base, in the spring of 1864, William Tecumseh Sherman would launch the campaign for Atlanta — and then his march to the sea. A defeat in September had set up the war-winning offensive of 1864.

*“Battle of Lookout Mountain, November 24, 1863” — chromolithograph, Kurz & Allison, public domain (Library of Congress).*

## Trace the Chain

YOUR TURN

*You'll put the campaign's events in order and practice cause and effect — explaining how a lost battle led to a won campaign, and what it opened up next.*